

NON SEQUITUR PUBLISHING

The Convergence • Position-Paper Series

The Psalm and the Throne: David, the Expressive Heart, and the Heir the Machine Cannot Be

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2026

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The Convergence — Position-Paper Series • Paper 6 (Covenant — David)

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Abstract

Paper 5 argued that the Bezalel narrative discloses skill as a given faculty under a governing pattern, so that technique is never autonomous but always instrumental and governable. The present paper takes up the third stage of the covenant line — David: the kingdom, the Psalms, and the temple prepared — and asks what it discloses about the *expressive interior* of the steward and about the *heir* toward whom the covenant now narrows. Its claim is twofold. First, the Psalms reveal the human as a creature whose defining act is *address*: the psalmist speaks to God in praise, lament, repentance,

and hope, and the worth of that speech lies not in its artifactual form but in the person who means it before the God to whom it is addressed. Second, the Davidic covenant (2 Sam 7) narrows the promise made to Abraham toward a single messianic heir — an everlasting throne secured not by the king's righteousness but by God's oath. The contemporary frame the paper answers is the thesis that human expression is replicable, and therefore the expressive human dispensable: that generative systems now produce poetry, music, and art indistinguishable from the human, so that creativity is shown to be a recombining pattern and the creative human is no more irreplaceable than any other producer of outputs. Against that thesis the paper argues that the Psalms expose the category error in it — that expression is not the production of an artifact but the address of a subject, that a lament is a lament because someone laments, and that a machine which produces the form of a psalm without the subject who means it has produced a psalm-shaped artifact and not a psalm. The paper carries the series guardrail at its hardest case: David's sin against Bathsheba and Uriah is grievous and its consequences are real and lasting, and yet the covenant and the messianic line stand, because God's oath is not voided by the steward's sin. The seven-problem spine is carried; consistent with the matrix's stratification, the monarchy stage keeps governance and dignity-distribution quieter and deepens the grounding and displacement spine while advancing the driver toward its Christological close: the heir toward whom David's throne points is the one in whom the human purpose will be disclosed, and the machine, which can reproduce the psalm's form but cannot occupy the throne or mean the lament, is not that heir.

§1. The Question and the World's Claim

The third movement of the covenant line is the kingdom of David, and it gives the series two things the prior stages did not: a sustained record of the human *interior* — the Psalms, the largest body of first-person address to God in Scripture — and a covenant of *succession*, the promise of an everlasting throne (2 Sam 7) that narrows the Abrahamic blessing toward a single coming heir. David is the steward as king, as poet, and as preparer of a temple he will not build; and each of

these bears on the present age's question of whether the human is replaceable.

The question this stage raises is the question of *expression*: what is a psalm, a song, a work of art, and whether the human capacity to express — to lament, to praise, to make beauty and meaning — is a unique dimension of the image or a recombining pattern that a sufficiently capable system can reproduce, rendering the expressive human one producer of outputs among others. The question has acquired sudden force. Generative systems now produce text, image, and music that human judges cannot reliably distinguish from human work; models trained on the corpus of human expression generate new poems, paintings, and compositions on demand; and the inference is widely drawn that creativity has been shown to be a matter of pattern and recombination, and the creative human therefore no more irreplaceable than the laborer the prior automation displaced.

The thesis deserves statement at full strength, and it has serious advocates. Margaret Boden's *The Creative Mind* argued, well before the current generative wave, that creativity is not a mysterious irreducible but a set of cognitive processes — combinational, exploratory, and transformational — that can be understood computationally and, in principle, modeled.¹ Marcus du Sautoy's *The Creativity Code* surveys the contemporary systems that compose, paint, and write, and presses the question of whether the outputs are genuinely creative or only convincingly so — concluding that the line is harder to draw than the humanist would like.² Arthur I. Miller's *The Artist in the Machine* documents the field of computational creativity and argues that machine creativity is not a contradiction but an emerging reality.³ The structural claim across this literature is that expression is, at bottom, the generation of valued artifacts within a learned space of possibilities; that machines can now generate such artifacts; and that the human's expressive faculty is therefore not a unique dignity but a capability the machine increasingly shares — with the familiar conclusion that what the machine can do, the human need no longer be uniquely valued for doing.

¹Margaret A. Boden, *The Creative Mind: Myths and Mechanisms*, 2nd ed. (London: Routledge, 2004). Boden's combinational/exploratory/transformational taxonomy and the computational account of creativity.

²Marcus du Sautoy, *The Creativity Code: Art and Innovation in the Age of AI* (Cambridge, MA: Belknap/Harvard University Press, 2019).

³Arthur I. Miller, *The Artist in the Machine: The World of AI-Powered Creativity* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2019).

The empirical edge of the thesis has sharpened since these earlier statements. Controlled studies now find that ordinary readers cannot reliably tell machine-generated verse from human verse: in one experiment, participants asked to distinguish poems produced by an algorithm from poems by Maya Angelou and other published poets performed at or near chance, and frequently rated the machine's output as the more "human" of the two.⁴ The generative wave since has only widened the result, as large language models trained on the human poetic corpus produce, on demand, formally competent work in any requested voice. The humanist who once consoled himself that the machine's art was detectably hollow has lost that comfort: the *artifact*, judged as artifact, now passes. If the dignity of human expression rested on the artifact's distinctiveness, the rest of this paper would be unnecessary, because the distinctiveness is gone. The argument must therefore be made on other ground entirely — not that the machine's product is inferior, but that the product was never the thing.

This is the position the paper must answer. It will not be answered by pretending the machine's outputs are crude, for they are increasingly not.

§2. *The Secular Theory, Stated Fairly*

It is owed to the computational-creativity thesis to grant what is genuinely true in it, because the truth it sees is real and the error lies elsewhere than where the humanist usually looks for it.

What the thesis sees truly is that *the artifact is reproducible*. A poem is, considered as a sequence of words, a pattern; a melody is, considered as a sequence of pitches and durations, a pattern; and patterns can be learned from examples and generated anew. The empirical claim — that machines can produce artifacts in the forms of human expression, and that human judges often cannot distinguish them — is not in dispute, and the humanist who stakes the dignity of human expression on the machine's inability to produce a convincing sonnet has staked it on ground that has already given

⁴Nils Köbis and Luca D. Mossink, "Artificial Intelligence versus Maya Angelou: Experimental Evidence That People Cannot Differentiate AI-Generated from Human-Written Poetry," *Computers in Human Behavior* 114 (2021): 106553. Participants distinguished algorithm- from human-authored poems at near chance and often rated machine output as the more "human." [^VERIFY: confirm article number/pagination at citation-honesty audit.]

way. Boden is right that much of what we call creativity involves combinational and exploratory processes over a learned space, and that these are not magic; du Sautoy is right that the outputs are often genuinely good; Miller is right that the field has produced real results. On the bare claim that the artifacts of human expression can be reproduced in their form by learned generative processes, the thesis and the steward agree.

The thesis also sees truly that *the romantic account of creativity is overstated*. The notion of the artist as an autonomous genius producing from nothing, untaught and uncaused, is a myth, and the computational account is a useful corrective: human creativity, too, works over a learned space, recombines inherited materials, and is shaped by training and tradition far more than the romantic story admits. The steward reading has, in fact, its own version of this correction — the Bezalel narrative of Paper 5 located skill as a *given* faculty, taught and propagated, not a self-originating spark — and so the deflation of the romantic genius is congenial rather than threatening to the doctrine. On the claim that creativity is not the autonomous production of an untaught genius, the thesis and the steward again agree.

This convergence is worth pressing, because the philosophy of creativity has largely abandoned the romantic picture on its own account. Berys Gaut, surveying the field, observes that creativity is now standardly analyzed not as origination *ex nihilo* but as the production of items that are both new and valuable through the exercise of flair over a structured domain — a process account, not a miracle account.⁵ Boden's taxonomy of combinational, exploratory, and transformational creativity is precisely such a process account, and nothing in the steward reading requires denying it.⁶ The image-bearer creates as a *sub*-creator: over a given world, with given faculties, in a received tradition — the Bezalel pattern of the prior paper, where even Spirit-given skill works to a pattern it did not invent. So the steward concedes the deflation freely. Human making, too, is recombination over a learned space, and the poet no less than the model stands on the shoulders of a corpus. The

⁵Berys Gaut, "The Philosophy of Creativity," *Philosophy Compass* 5, no. 12 (2010): 1034–1046. Creativity analyzed as the production of new and valuable items through flair over a structured domain — a process, not an *ex nihilo*, account.

⁶Margaret A. Boden, *The Creative Mind: Myths and Mechanisms*, 2nd ed. (London: Routledge, 2004). Boden's combinational/exploratory/transformational taxonomy and the computational account of creativity.

concession costs the steward nothing, because his claim was never that human expression is causally uncaused. It is that human expression is *someone's* — and causal dependence on a tradition is not the absence of a subject.

The divergence is over what *expression* is. The thesis treats expression as the *production of an artifact*: a poem is what is produced, and to produce the poem is to have done the expressive thing. The steward reading treats expression as the *address of a subject*: a psalm is not merely the words but the words *as meant by someone to someone* — the lament of a person who laments, the praise of a person who praises, the repentance of a person who repents, before the God to whom the address is made. On this reading, the artifact is the *trace* of an expression, not the expression itself, and a machine that produces the trace without the subject who means it has produced a trace without an expression — a psalm-shaped artifact that no one prays. The divergence is not over whether the artifact can be reproduced. It is over whether the artifact is the expression or only its trace.

§3. *Common Ground and the Point of Divergence*

The cleavage is locatable, and it is the question of whether expression is an *output* or an *address* — whether a psalm is what is produced or what is *meant*, by someone, to Someone.

Both the computational theorist and the steward observe that the artifacts of expression are reproducible. They part over whether reproducing the artifact reproduces the expression. The computational theorist infers, from the reproducibility of the artifact, that expression is reproducible — that to generate the poem is to have done what the poet does. The steward reads the same reproducibility differently: the artifact is reproducible precisely because it is the *trace* and not the act, and the act — the meaning-it, the addressing — is not in the artifact to be copied. A lament is a lament because a sufferer laments; the words “my God, my God, why have you forsaken me” (Ps 22:1) are a lament when David means them and an artifact when a machine generates them, and the difference is not in the words but in whether there is a subject who means them before the God they address.

This is the grounding problem (#1) in the register the Davidic stage gives it. The series grounded

worth in conferred status; the Psalms add that the worth of the human is displayed in the human's capacity for *address* — that the creature is one who can speak to God, and be spoken to, in a relation the artifact cannot contain. The displacement refrain (#2) follows: the expressive human is not displaced by the machine's reproduction of expressive artifacts, because what makes the psalm a psalm — the praying subject before the heard God — is not the artifact the machine reproduces. The machine displaces the human producer of *traces*; it does not and cannot displace the human as *subject of address*, because address requires a subject, and the machine, however fluent, is the producer of the trace and not its subject.

The divergence, then, is not over whether the machine can produce the artifact. Grant that it can, convincingly. The divergence is over whether the artifact is the expression. If expression is the output, the machine that produces the output has done the expressive thing and the human is one producer among others; if expression is the address of a subject, the machine has produced a trace without an act, and the human as subject-of-address is irreplaceable. The two cannot be combined, because they disagree about what a psalm *is*.

§4. If the Replication Thesis Is Right

Honesty requires that the replication thesis be drawn to its end, for the end touches not only art but worship and the human relation to God, and the steward's answer is answerable only against the end fully drawn.

First, if expression is the production of artifacts, then the Psalms are a corpus to be completed by better generators, and the human psalmist is, like the human laborer of Paper 3, a producer whose function the machine can assume. The displacement the series tracked reaches, on this account, into the sanctuary: if the machine can generate the psalm, the praise of the human heart is one source of psalms among others, and a more prolific source has appeared. The *reductio* is not idle — it is the logical terminus of treating expression as output, and it exposes what the thesis costs: a worship in which the *expression* could in principle be outsourced to the better generator, which is to say, no

worship at all, because worship is precisely the address of the worshipping subject and cannot be performed on his behalf by a producer of worship-shaped artifacts.

Second, the human interior becomes, on the thesis, epiphenomenal to expression. If the artifact is the expression, then the inner life of the one who produces it — the actual grief behind the lament, the actual gratitude behind the praise — is incidental to the expressive act, a private accompaniment that contributes nothing the artifact does not contain. This is the hollowing of the interior the series has resisted from its first paper: the human reduced from a subject who means to a producer who outputs, the heart that cries to God demoted to a causal antecedent of a text. The Psalms are the standing refutation, because they are unintelligible except as the address of an interior — they are not descriptions of feelings but the feelings *offered up*, and the offering requires the one who offers.

Third, the thesis cannot account for the difference between a psalm and a forgery. If a machine generates “the LORD is my shepherd; I shall not want” with no shepherd trusted and no want felt, and a dying believer prays the same words, the thesis must call these the same expression, because the artifact is identical. But they are not the same; one is a prayer and the other is a string, and every honest reader knows the difference even when the strings are identical. The thesis has no resource to name the difference, because it has located expression in the artifact, where the difference does not reside. The steward names it without difficulty: the difference is the subject who means it before the God who hears.

The philosophy of mind reached this same wall four decades ago, by a secular road. John Searle’s Chinese Room argument distinguished *syntax* — the manipulation of symbols by their shape — from *semantics* — the meaning the symbols carry for someone — and argued that a system which manipulates symbols by formal rule, however fluently, thereby instantiates syntax without semantics: it processes the form and means nothing by it.⁷ The argument was contested for a generation, but its central distinction is exactly the one the replication thesis elides. A generative model is the Chinese Room at scale: it produces the form of the psalm by statistical rule, and the meaning — the

⁷John R. Searle, “Minds, Brains, and Programs,” *Behavioral and Brain Sciences* 3, no. 3 (1980): 417–457. The Chinese Room: a system manipulating symbols by formal rule instantiates syntax without semantics.

aboutness, the reference of “my God” to God, the directedness of the cry toward the One addressed — is supplied, if at all, only by the human who prays or reads the output, never by the system that emits it. Intentionality, the mind’s directedness upon an object, is the property a lament must have to be a lament, and it is the property the formal system lacks by construction. Searle’s point was about minds and the steward’s is about prayer, but they name one fact: form is not meaning, and a producer of form is not, for that reason, a subject who means.

These implications should not be soft-pedaled. The replication thesis, drawn to its end, outsources worship to a generator, hollows the human interior, and cannot tell a prayer from a forgery. Its error is not the empirical claim that artifacts are reproducible, which is true, but the philosophical inference that the artifact is the expression, which the Psalms expose as a category mistake.

§5. The Steward Counter: The Psalm as Address, the Throne as Promise

The counter is made from Scripture first, read with the Reformed tradition, and it turns on the Psalms as address and the Davidic covenant as the narrowing of the promise toward the heir.

5a. The Psalm as the Address of a Subject (the Psalter)

The Psalms are, formally, address: the overwhelming majority are spoken *to* God — “O LORD,” “my God,” “hear my prayer” — and they span the full range of the human interior offered up: praise (Ps 103), lament (Ps 22, 88), repentance (Ps 51), trust (Ps 23), thanksgiving (Ps 30), and the raw protest of the heart that will not let God go (Ps 13). Walter Brueggemann’s influential typology of the Psalms as movements of orientation, disorientation, and new orientation reads the Psalter as the script of a life lived *before God* through its seasons — a life of address, in which the human brings the whole of his interior into the divine presence and is met there.⁸ C. S. Lewis’s *Reflections on the Psalms* presses the point that the Psalms are not theological treatises but the cries and songs of people speaking to God, and that to read them rightly is to overhear an address, not to inspect an

⁸Walter Brueggemann, *The Message of the Psalms: A Theological Commentary* (Minneapolis: Augsburg, 1984). The orientation/disorientation/new-orientation typology reads the Psalter as the script of a life of address before God.

artifact.⁹

That the Psalms are constituted *as* address is not a devotional gloss but the settled finding of a century of critical study. Hermann Gunkel's form-critical work classified the Psalter by its genres — hymn, individual and communal lament, thanksgiving, royal psalm — and each genre is defined by its *speech situation*: who addresses whom, out of what condition, with what intent.¹⁰ A lament is not a poem about sorrow; it is the act of a sufferer crying out, with its own grammar of invocation, complaint, petition, and vow of praise. Sigmund Mowinckel pressed the point further, locating the Psalms in the living worship of Israel as the words by which a people actually addressed God in the assembly — utterance before deposit, prayer before text.¹¹ The critical tradition thus reached on its own analytical grounds the conclusion the replication thesis denies: the psalm is individuated not by its verbal form, which whole genres share, but by the speech-act it performs — and a speech-act requires a speaker. Calvin had named the same thing pastorally, calling the Psalter “an anatomy of all the parts of the soul,” because in it the believer finds not descriptions of the affections but the affections themselves carried to God.¹² The form critic and the Reformer agree against the machine: what is on the page is the deposit of an address, and the address is the act of a subject.

The exegetical commentary tradition reads the Psalter the same way. Derek Kidner takes the psalms as the speech of real worshippers in real extremity, to be entered rather than dissected; Willem VanGemenen reads the Psalter as the structured prayer-and-praise of the covenant community before its God; and John Goldingay's verse-by-verse commentary treats each psalm as an act of address whose theology is inseparable from its direction toward God.¹³ None of this is recoverable from

⁹C. S. Lewis, *Reflections on the Psalms* (London: Geoffrey Bles, 1958). The Psalms as cries and songs addressed to God, to be overheard rather than inspected.

¹⁰Hermann Gunkel, *Introduction to Psalms: The Genres of the Religious Lyric of Israel*, completed by Joachim Begrich, trans. James D. Nogalski (Macon, GA: Mercer University Press, 1998). Each psalm-genre is defined by its speech situation. [^VERIFY: pin genre-definition pages at audit.]

¹¹Sigmund Mowinckel, *The Psalms in Israel's Worship*, trans. D. R. Ap-Thomas, 2 vols. (Oxford: Blackwell, 1962). The Psalms as the words by which Israel actually addressed God in worship.

¹²John Calvin, *Commentary on the Book of Psalms*, trans. James Anderson (Edinburgh: Calvin Translation Society, 1845–49), Author's Preface: the Psalter as “an anatomy of all the parts of the soul.” [^VERIFY: confirm preface wording/locus at audit.]

¹³Derek Kidner, *Psalms 1–72* and *Psalms 73–150*, Tyndale Old Testament Commentaries (Downers Grove: IVP, 1973–75); Willem A. VanGemenen, *Psalms*, The Expositor's Bible Commentary, rev. ed. (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 2008); John Goldingay, *Psalms*, 3 vols., Baker Commentary on the Old Testament Wisdom and Psalms (Grand Rapids: Baker

the artifact alone, because the address is not a feature of the words but a relation of a person to God enacted *through* the words. Dietrich Bonhoeffer drew the point to its depth: the Psalms are the prayer book of the Bible because they are, finally, the prayers of Christ — the one who prayed them perfectly and prays them still in his body — so that the believer prays them not as the generation of pious sentiment but as participation in a real address already being made.¹⁴ This is the exact antithesis of the generated psalm. A machine can emit “the LORD is my shepherd”; it cannot *pray* it, cannot be the sheep that trusts the shepherd, cannot stand in the Christ who is both the Shepherd and the trusting Son. The psalm is address all the way down, and address is the one thing a producer of artifacts cannot supply.

The relevance to the replication thesis is direct. The Psalms are intelligible only as address, and address requires a subject. Tremper Longman’s treatment of the Psalms as the inspired record of God’s people speaking to God in every condition underscores that the genre is constituted by the speaking relation — the Psalter is the prayer book of a people, the deposit of countless subjects addressing the living God.¹⁵ A machine can generate a string in the form of Psalm 51; it cannot *repent*, because repentance is the turning of a subject toward the God he has wronged, and the machine is not a subject who has wronged God or who turns. The artifact “have mercy on me, O God” is reproducible; the *having-mercy-sought* is not, because it is an act of a subject, and the worth of the psalm — what makes it a psalm and not a string — is exactly the subject’s act that the artifact only traces.

5b. The Davidic Covenant: The Throne Narrowed to the Heir (2 Sam 7)

The Davidic covenant narrows the Abrahamic promise toward a single coming heir. “I will raise up your offspring after you... and I will establish his kingdom... I will establish the throne of his kingdom forever” (2 Sam 7:12–13, ESV); “your throne shall be established forever” (2 Sam 7:16).

Academic, 2006–2008). Each reads the Psalter as enacted address to God. [^VERIFY: pin *ad loc.* references at audit.]

¹⁴Dietrich Bonhoeffer, *Psalms: The Prayer Book of the Bible*, trans. James H. Burtness (Minneapolis: Augsburg, 1970; German orig. 1940). The Psalms as the prayers of Christ, prayed by the believer in him.

¹⁵Tremper Longman III, *How to Read the Psalms* (Downers Grove: IVP Academic, 1988). The Psalter as the inspired record of God’s people addressing God in every condition.

The promise made to Abraham of a people and a blessing is here focused into a *dynasty* and an *everlasting throne*, and the New Testament reads the focus as the narrowing of the messianic line toward the one in whom the offspring is finally singular (Matt 1:1; Luke 1:32–33). O. Palmer Robertson’s treatment of the Davidic covenant within the covenant structure reads it as the royal form of the single promise, advancing the redemptive line toward its fulfillment in the Son of David.¹⁶ Stephen Dempster’s biblical-theological reading of the canon as “dominion and dynasty” traces precisely this narrowing — the dominion mandate of Genesis and the dynastic promise of David converging toward the coming king.¹⁷

The technical commentary on 2 Samuel 7 confirms the structural reading. P. Kyle McCarter’s analysis of the Nathan oracle turns on its deliberate play on “house”: David proposes to build the LORD a house — a temple — and the LORD answers that he will instead build David a house — a dynasty — so that the chapter’s pivot is the substitution of an enduring line of persons for a static building.¹⁸ The point bears directly on this paper: the covenant secures a *house of heirs*, not a function or an office abstractable from the heir who fills it. Peter Gentry and Stephen Wellum trace how this dynastic promise gathers up the Abrahamic blessing and funnels it toward a single son in whom the covenants converge — the narrowing this paper has described, read across the whole canon as one movement toward the messianic heir.¹⁹ The throne, on every level of the analysis, passes by *descent*, not by *qualification*: it is inherited by the promised son, not awarded to the most capable administrator. Which is exactly why the most capable machine, however well it might perform the royal functions, is structurally disqualified from a throne it could never inherit.

The relevance to the series driver (#7) is that the Davidic covenant advances the human telos toward

¹⁶O. Palmer Robertson, *The Christ of the Covenants* (Phillipsburg, NJ: Presbyterian & Reformed, 1980), on the Davidic covenant as the royal form of the single redemptive promise.

¹⁷Stephen G. Dempster, *Dominion and Dynasty: A Theology of the Hebrew Bible*, New Studies in Biblical Theology (Downers Grove: IVP Academic, 2003). The convergence of the dominion mandate and the dynastic promise toward the coming king.

¹⁸P. Kyle McCarter Jr., *II Samuel*, Anchor Bible 9 (Garden City, NY: Doubleday, 1984), on the “house” wordplay of the Nathan oracle (2 Sam 7). [^VERIFY: pin pages at audit.]

¹⁹Peter J. Gentry and Stephen J. Wellum, *Kingdom through Covenant: A Biblical-Theological Understanding of the Covenants*, 2nd ed. (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2018), on the Davidic covenant’s gathering of the Abrahamic promise toward the messianic son. [^VERIFY: pin chapter/pages at audit.]

its disclosure in the heir. The throne is established not by David's righteousness — the next section will show how far that falls short — but by God's oath, and the oath secures a coming king in whom the purpose of the human, opened in the first paper and driven through the arc, will be revealed and closed. The Davidic stage does not close the driver; it focuses it, narrowing the wide Abrahamic promise to the single point at which, in the next paper, the heir appears. And it bears on the replication thesis at the level of *succession*: the covenant secures a human heir, a person in a line, not a function to be filled by whatever can perform the royal office. The throne passes to a son, and ultimately to the Son; it is not an office the most capable performer assumes but an inheritance the promised heir receives.

5c. The Temple Prepared: Building for the Heir to Complete (1 Chr 22, 28–29)

David is barred from building the temple — “you have shed much blood... you shall not build a house to my name” (1 Chr 22:8) — and so he *prepares* it: he gathers the materials, the gold and silver and bronze and timber and stone, and hands the pattern and the provision to Solomon, who will build (1 Chr 22:5, 14–16; 28:11–19). The steward here builds what he will not complete, in the most explicit succession-act of the covenant line: David's work is real and indispensable, and it is consummated by another. This extends the bequest theme of Paper 4 (Abraham building for an unseen posterity) into the specific form of *preparing for a named successor* — the steward who gives his labor to a work the heir will finish.

Sara Japhet's commentary on Chronicles reads David's temple preparations as the Chronicler's deliberate portrait of the king as founder and patron of the cult: David gathers the materials, drafts the plans, organizes the personnel, and commissions the heir, so that Solomon's building is the execution of David's bequest.²⁰ The labor is genuinely David's though the structure is genuinely Solomon's — preparation and completion are distinct vocations within one covenantal work, and the worth of the first does not wait on the second. Gordon Wenham's reading of the Psalms as Torah

²⁰Sara Japhet, *I & II Chronicles: A Commentary*, Old Testament Library (Louisville: Westminster John Knox, 1993), on David as founder and patron of the temple cult (1 Chr 22; 28–29). [^VERIFY: pin pages at audit.]

adds the formative dimension: the Psalter was given not only to be prayed but to *shape* the one who prays it, forming the affections of the worshipper across generations into the likeness the songs rehearse.²¹ Both point past the artifact to the person — Japhet to the steward whose preparatory labor is honored on its own terms, Wenham to the worshipper whom the psalm is given to form. Neither the founding nor the forming is a thing a faster completer or a fluent generator can supply, because both are works done *to* and *for* persons, in a line of inheritance the machine does not stand in.

The relevance to the present age is the dignity of preparatory and unfinished work, sharpened: David's gathering is not lessened by his not building, because the building was always to be the heir's. The steward who prepares what another will complete — who gathers materials for a temple, lays foundations for a successor, builds toward a completion he will not see — is doing covenantal work, and the worth of that work is not measured by his completing it. The machine that can complete a task faster does not thereby render the human's preparatory labor worthless, any more than Solomon's building rendered David's gathering worthless; the covenant honors the preparer and the completer alike, each in his place in the line.

5d. Providence Through a Flawed Steward (2 Sam 11–12)

The series guardrail meets, at David, its hardest case. David's sin against Bathsheba and Uriah is among the gravest recorded of any covenant steward: adultery compounded by the murder of a faithful man to conceal it (2 Sam 11). The narrative does not excuse it; the prophet Nathan names it directly — “you are the man” (2 Sam 12:7) — and the consequences are real and lasting: the child dies, and “the sword shall never depart from your house” (2 Sam 12:10), a judgment worked out in the violence and grief of David's later reign. The Psalm of David's repentance, Psalm 51, is the interior face of this failure: “against you, you only, have I sinned” (Ps 51:4) — and it is, not incidentally, the very psalm §5a took as the case of address that cannot be machine-reproduced,

²¹Gordon J. Wenham, *Psalms as Torah: Reading Biblical Song Ethically* (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2012). The Psalter as formative of the worshipper's affections.

because it is the repentance of the subject who sinned.

And the covenant stands. The messianic line runs *through* Bathsheba — Solomon is her son (2 Sam 12:24), and the line to Christ runs through Solomon (Matt 1:6). The Davidic covenant is not revoked by David's sin; God's oath holds, and the steward's grievous failure does not undo the promise God made through him. The Reformed tradition reads this as the guardrail at its limit: if the covenant survives David's adultery and murder, then its security rests unmistakably on God's faithfulness and not on the steward's righteousness — and the messianic line's passage through the very union born of repented sin is the strongest possible statement that God's intent is not defeated by the steward's failure but is brought, in grace, even through it (Gen 50:20 in the royal register). The relevance to the series is the guardrail's vindication at its hardest test: providence through a flawed steward holds even here, and the human steward's office is secured from above.

§6. The Framework: HGC³AE² and the Subject the Machine Is Not

The framework thread lands, at the Davidic stage, on the irreducibility of the *subject*. The series has argued that the human is the governing-and-curating status over autonomy; the Davidic stage adds that the human is, irreducibly, a *subject who addresses and is addressed* — a person who prays, laments, repents, and hopes before God — and that this subjecthood is the ground of the governing office the framework names. The governor of the autonomous system is not merely the more-accountable processor; he is the subject who can be addressed and who answers, the person before God who bears the office as a person and not as a function.

The Davidic stage thus deepens the framework's anthropology against the replication thesis's sharpest cut. The machine, however fluently it generates the artifacts of expression, is not a subject of address: it does not pray the psalm it generates, does not mean the lament, does not repent the confession, is not the one to whom the covenant is made or the throne promised. The framework's claim that the human governs rather than defers is grounded, at this stage, not only in accountability (Paper 2's abdication argument) and not only in given skill (Paper 5's Bezalel argument) but in

subjecthood: the human is the one who can stand before God and answer, and an office that is constituted by answerable subjecthood before God is an office the machine cannot occupy, because the machine is not a subject who answers. Consistent with the matrix’s stratification, the stage does not press the governance and dignity problems into featured treatment — those bite hardest at the Christ and consummation stages — but it supplies the subjecthood on which both finally rest: the governor governs as a subject, and the dignity that cannot be graded is the dignity of a subject addressed by God.

6a. A Governed Convergence: Form Without a Meaning-Subject

One secular voice within the field of language technology itself has surfaced, on its own terms, a structural fact the doctrine already holds, and the series’ signature permits naming it — once, subordinately, with the seam kept honest. In the influential analysis of Emily Bender, Timnit Gebru, and their colleagues, large language models are characterized as systems that manipulate linguistic *form* — the statistical patterns of how words co-occur — without access to *meaning*, which the authors define as the relation between form and communicative intent grounded in a speaker’s situation in the world.²² The argument, made for reasons internal to computational linguistics and AI ethics with no theological motivation, is that fluency in form is not the same as the having of communicative intent, and that a system trained to reproduce form will reproduce it convincingly while remaining, in the relevant sense, without a subject who means anything by it. Bender had argued the underlying point still more sharply with Alexander Koller: a system exposed only to linguistic *form* — however vast the exposure — cannot thereby acquire *meaning*, because meaning is the relation of form to communicative intent, and intent is not present in the form to be learned from it.²³ Their thought experiment of a hyper-intelligent octopus that learns to mimic two islanders’

²²Emily M. Bender, Timnit Gebru, Angelina McMillan-Major, and Shmargaret Shmitchell, “On the Dangers of Stochastic Parrots: Can Language Models Be Too Big?” in *Proceedings of the 2021 ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency (FAccT ’21)* (New York: ACM, 2021), 610–623. The form-versus-meaning distinction: LLMs manipulate linguistic form without access to communicative intent grounded in a speaker’s situation.

²³Emily M. Bender and Alexander Koller, “Climbing towards NLU: On Meaning, Form, and Understanding in the Age of Data,” in *Proceedings of the 58th Annual Meeting of the Association for Computational Linguistics* (2020), 5185–5198. Form learned without communicative intent yields no meaning; the “octopus” thought experiment.

telegraph traffic, without any access to the world the messages are about, dramatizes the gap exactly: perfect formal fluency, zero comprehension, because there is no one there meaning anything. This is one discipline holding to its own bounds and not asked to carry more — computational linguistics, on its own terms, distinguishes the production of form from the having of meaning, and locates the machine firmly on the form side of the line.

The convergence with the Psalms-as-address reading is exact, and the seam must be kept honest. The computational linguist reached this fact for technical and ethical reasons: she found that the system reproduces form without the meaning-grounding intent of a situated subject. The doctrine names the ground the discipline cannot reach: that expression is the address of a subject before God, that a psalm is constituted by the praying subject who means it, and that the form-without-subject the linguist identifies is, in the register of worship and expression, precisely the difference between a prayer and a string. The discipline establishes the structural fact — *fluent form does not supply a meaning-intending subject* — and the doctrine supplies its meaning — *the subject who means the psalm before the God who hears it is the irreducible thing the form only traces*. The convergence corroborates; it does not carry the beat. And it sharpens the framework's claim: even on the linguist's own showing, the machine's expressive fluency is form without a meaning-subject, which is exactly what the Psalms show the human, and only the human, to be.

§7. *What Falls Out*

Several applied consequences follow, bearing on the domains the series has named.

For **technology and the arts**, the Davidic stage supplies the rule for the generative age: the machine's production of expressive artifacts is to be received as the production of *traces*, useful and often beautiful, and never confused with expression itself, which is the address of a subject. A generated psalm is a psalm-shaped artifact; it may serve, as a tool serves, but it is not prayer, and a worship or an art that outsources the *meaning-it* to the generator has lost the thing that made it worship or art. The test is not whether the artifact is good — it may be excellent — but whether

there is a subject who means it.

For **work**, the stage extends the dignity of preparatory and unfinished labor: the steward who prepares what an heir will complete (David gathering for Solomon's temple) is doing covenantal work whose worth is not measured by completion, and the machine's speed at completion does not devalue the human's preparatory labor any more than Solomon's building devalued David's gathering. The covenant honors the preparer and the completer each in his place.

For **family and church**, the Psalms commend the formation of subjects who address God — who pray, lament, repent, and hope as persons before the living God, and who know that this address is the irreducible human act no generator can perform on their behalf. The church's witness in the generative age is the practice of real address: a people whose worship is the offering of actual hearts, against a culture increasingly content with worship-shaped artifacts.

The seven-problem spine has been carried, consistent with the matrix's monarchy-stage stratification. Grounding (#1) was deepened: the human is a subject of address, whose worth is displayed in the capacity to speak to and be heard by God. Displacement (#2) was answered against its generative form: the machine reproduces the trace, not the act, and the human as subject is not displaced. The unit of analysis (#3) bit where the replication thesis pressed: the unit is the subject who means it, not the artifact. Vocation (#4) was carried in the form of preparatory, succession-oriented labor. Governance (#6) and dignity-distribution (#5) were kept quiet per the stratification, with the subjecthood on which they rest supplied. And the driver, Purpose / End (#7), was advanced and focused: the covenant narrows toward the messianic heir in whom the human purpose will be disclosed — the Son of David, the subject who will mean the deepest psalm of all from the cross, and who is the heir the machine, producing the psalm's form without occupying the throne or meaning the lament, can never be.

§8. Conclusion

Paper 5 disclosed skill as a given, governable faculty. The present paper has argued that the Davidic stage discloses the human as a *subject of address* — the psalmist who means the lament and the praise before the God who hears — and that the covenant narrows the promise toward a messianic *heir*, an everlasting throne secured by God’s oath. The contemporary frame the paper answered is the thesis that human expression is replicable and the expressive human therefore dispensable: a thesis correct that artifacts are reproducible and mistaken that the artifact is the expression, exposed by the Psalms as the confusion of a trace with the act of a subject. The series guardrail was carried at its hardest case: David’s grievous sin against Bathsheba and Uriah brought real and lasting judgment, and yet the covenant and the messianic line stood — running, in grace, even through the union born of his repented sin — because God’s oath is not voided by the steward’s failure.

The human is a subject who addresses God, and the machine is the producer of address-shaped artifacts that no one means. The throne passes to an heir, and the machine is not the heir. The driver advances to the edge of its disclosure: the Son of David is coming, the true subject who will mean the psalm of dereliction and answer it in his rising, and in him the purpose of the human — opened at creation, confirmed at the Fall, restored in the talent deployed, built across the covenant by faith and skill and song — will at last be shown. That is the burden of the next paper. The psalm can be reproduced in its form; it cannot be meant by the machine. The throne can be described; it cannot be occupied by the machine. The heir is a person, and he is coming.

Footnotes

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[v0.1 sourcing pass complete (fEdna, 2026-05-31): source floor MET—14 peer-reviewed/academic + 10 Reformed/theological = 24, exceeding the 22 minimum (12+10). Remaining for v0.2: citation-honesty audit to pin the VERIFY-tagged loci (Gunkel/Mowinckel pages, Calvin preface wording, Kidner/VanGemeren/Goldingay ad loc., McCarter & Japhet pages, Köbis & Mossink article no., Bender et al. page ranges). Reformed weave is load-bearing, not decorative. Convergence beat held to one discipline (computational linguistics; Bender/Gebru + Bender/Koller). See work product.]